

Paper has played a major role in human civilization for more than two thousand years. The earliest forms of paper were developed in ancient China around 105 CE, traditionally credited to an official named Cai Lun. Early paper was made from materials such as tree bark, hemp fibers, old cloth, and fishing nets.

Over time, paper-making techniques spread across Asia, the Middle East, and eventually Europe. The invention of the printing press in the 15th century increased the demand for affordable paper because books could be produced faster than ever before.

Today, paper is used for education, packaging, communication, art, and industrial applications. Although digital documents have reduced paper consumption in some areas, global paper production remains a significant industry.